Chapter 1 · Story

Maya arrives late. The room has already decided why.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

Leo is assigning the opening shift. What is his most informative next move?

A Ask Maya about today and check her availability.

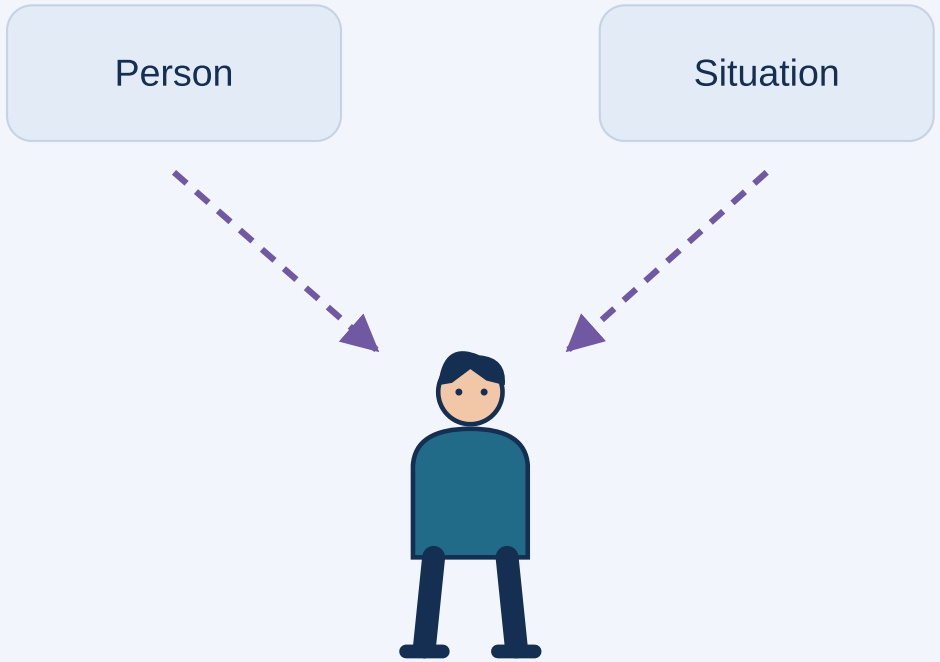
B Use today’s lateness as the main sign of reliability.

C Ignore today and assume she will arrive on time.

Suggested answer: A. Asking Maya about the delay lets Leo investigate the obstacle and plan the shift without ignoring the lateness.

Behavior has more than one author.

- Person: habits, values, skills
- Situation: constraints, roles, incentives
- Interaction: a setting affects people differently

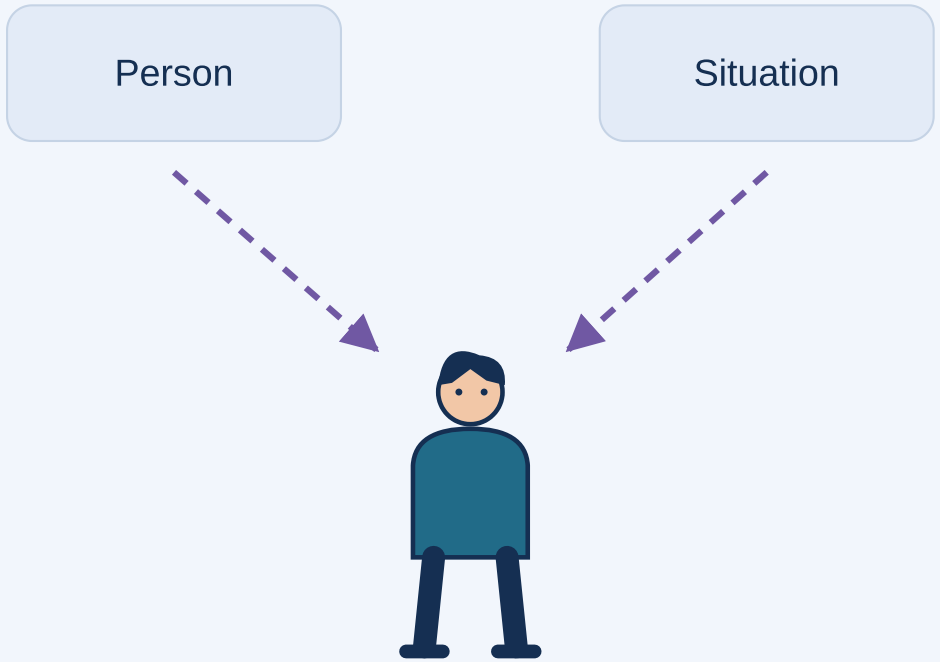


Behavior emerges in context.

Person and situation both contribute to behavior.

Observation is not explanation.

- Observed: Maya arrived after the start.
- Inferred: Maya does not care.
- Test: ask what changes across situations.

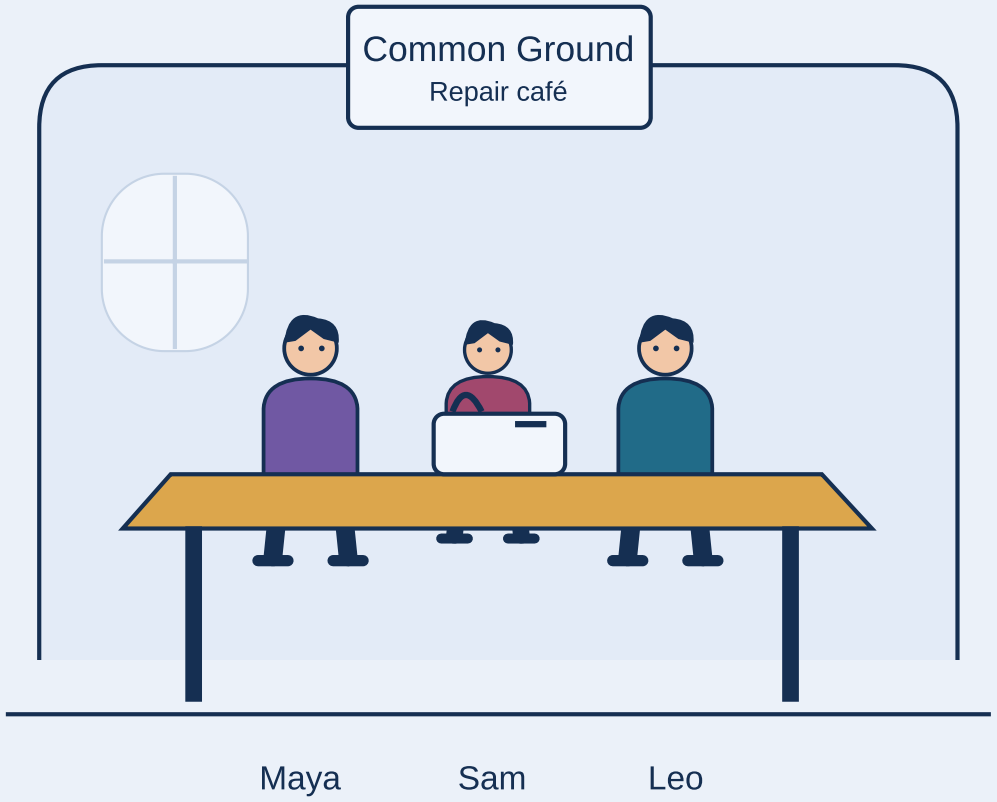


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Person and situation both contribute to behavior.

What can we really conclude?

Attribution research describes tendencies in judgment. It does not establish that personal qualities never matter. Repeated behavior across varied settings is more informative than one episode. Effects such as actor–observer differences depend on the judgment and the study design. Use a bias label to ask a better question about the evidence. The label alone cannot reveal what is happening in someone else’s mind.



Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

A volunteer misses shifts only when the bus service is suspended. What should you test?

A Whether personality alone predicts attendance.

B Whether another travel plan improves attendance.

C Whether the missed shifts can be deleted.

Suggested answer: B. Trying another travel plan tests the suspected barrier while keeping the attendance expectation clear.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Explain observation versus attribution.

> What would strengthen a personal explanation?

1. An observation records an action. An attribution proposes a cause for that action.

2. A personal explanation becomes more credible when the pattern recurs across varied circumstances and plausible alternatives have been examined.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Choose a mildly frustrating encounter. Write the action, your first interpretation, two alternatives, and one respectful question that could clarify it.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.